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So Near, and Yet So Far

A month before the Rome Olympics, the preliminaries were held in London. While sitting in the gallery watching the races, I observed the black French athlete, Abdul Saye, clock an unbelievable 45.9 seconds in the 400-metre event. This was a sensational record and was most worrying because my timing in the same race was a little over 46 seconds. When the French heard that Milkha Singh was part of the Indian Olympic team they invited me to France for the next preliminaries in which reputed sprinters from England, Jamaica, the West Indies and Kenya were participating. This was just a week or so before the Olympics .

My track record before this event had been impeccable. I had run many races and won against other world-class athletes, but Abdul Saye was a challenge. Usually I had beaten other contestants by a margin of five or seven yards, but could I do the same this time? Commander Pereira, in his broken Hindustani, did his best to motivate me, saying, ‘Milkha Singh, you must beat Abdul Saye today.’

In the stadium, the mostly French audience watched as I went through my warm-up exercises. To them, I was a curiosity with my long hair, turban and kara and they did not know what to except of me. When the race began, I ran with a vengeance, straining every muscle and won, establishing a new record of 45.8 seconds—point one second less than the previous Olympic record of 45.9. My achievement made headline news in the international press the next day. When I returned to my hotel room, I watched the reruns of the race that were being telecast on television. It was a new experience to